18. The Future of India–China Relations

In the Chinese classic *Romance of the Three Kingdoms* , there is a story known as ‘The Ruse of the Empty City’, which is part of Chinese lore. Its hero is Zhuge Liang, a general of the Shu kingdom. His fortress city of Xicheng was besieged and in danger of being overrun by a much superior force deployed by the rival army of the Wei kingdom. Zhuge Liang ordered all the city gates to be opened and asked all his soldiers to don the clothes of ordinary householders and go about their daily humdrum activities in full view of the advancing army. Zhuge Liang parked himself on top of one of the city gates, calmly strumming on the qin, a Chinese string instrument. The Wei general Sima Yi, confronted with this strange spectacle, suspected he would run into an ambush if he entered the city gates and therefore quickly withdrew. The day was saved for Shu. Zhuge Liang is credited with the observation that to win a war it is necessary to steal into the mind of one’s adversary, observe his thought processes, and then fashion an appropriate strategy.

This fascinating tale from ancient China underscores the need of a much deeper understanding of the nature of Chinese civilization, its cultural particularities and the world view of its people, formed layer upon layer, over 5,000 years of unbroken though sometimes tumultuous history. Developing such an understanding is an indispensable part of any credible strategy to meet the China challenge, and this book has been an attempt to contribute to that understanding.

One cannot, however, apply historical patterns mechanistically as a prism through which to understand present-day China. China is undergoing a dramatic transformation and its traditional culture and ways of thinking can no longer be sourced only to persisting templates of the past. For example, its Leninist one-party state is a modern artefact which has adapted and moulded concepts inherited from the past, but has also jettisoned many elements that are considered to have lost relevance. There are concepts and